

When PALMs are in your THOUGHTs, where do you go?

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1. INTRODUCTION

- Past research has argued for dialect contact between New York City (NYC), New Orleans, and sometimes Charleston, based on shared features between the cities (Table 1) (e.g., Berger 1980; Labov 2007; Carmichael & Becker 2018).
- In this poster, we:
 - argue that Baltimore also participated in maritime dialect contact in the United States.
 - present evidence for Baltimore’s influence on the New Orleans low back system.

Feature	White New Yorkers	White New Orleanians	White Charlestonians	White Baltimoreans	Black Baltimoreans
Monophthongal PRICE	No	Yes	No	Yes	Yes
Fronted GOOSE	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	Primarily after coronals
Fronted GOAT	No	Yes	No	Yes	No
Raised pre-voiceless MOUTH	No	No ^A	Yes	No	Yes [8]
Fronted MOUTH	No	Primarily after nasals	No	Yes	Primarily after nasals
Short-a split with raised BATH ^B	Yes (Labov et al. 2006)	Yes (Labov et al. 2006)	No (Labov et al. 2006)	Yes (Labov et al. 2006)	No
Raised THOUGHT	Yes, to (high) mid position (Labov et al. 2006)	Yes, to (low) mid position (Labov et al. 2006)	Yes, to (low) mid position (Baranowski 2013)	Yes, to (low) mid position	Yes, to (low) mid position
Raised START	No	Yes (Dinkin & Carmichael 2025)	No	Yes	Yes
Palatalized NURSE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Sporadically in region	N/A
Non-rhoticity	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes (now rare)	Yes

^A Pre-voiceless MOUTH-raising has recently emerged in New Orleans.
^B The conditions on the short-a split differ between NYC, New Orleans, and Baltimore (Labov et al. 2006; Labov 2007).

Table 1. Shared features in the earlier English of New York City and major Southern ports. Except where noted, (i) information for NYC and Charleston is based on Kurath & McDavid 1961; (ii) information for New Orleans is based on Carmichael 2014; and (iii) information for Baltimore is based on Kurath & McDavid 1961 and the authors’ research except where noted.

- Baltimore was the center of early American Catholicism.
 - The New Orleans diocese was administered by the Bishop of Baltimore from 1809–1815 (Bishops of archdiocese n.d.).
 - Many wealthy Louisianans had their children educated at Baltimore’s St. Mary’s College, a Sulpician-run secondary school (Arnold 2015).
- Baltimore imported and processed sugar and cotton from Louisiana (Arnold 2015).

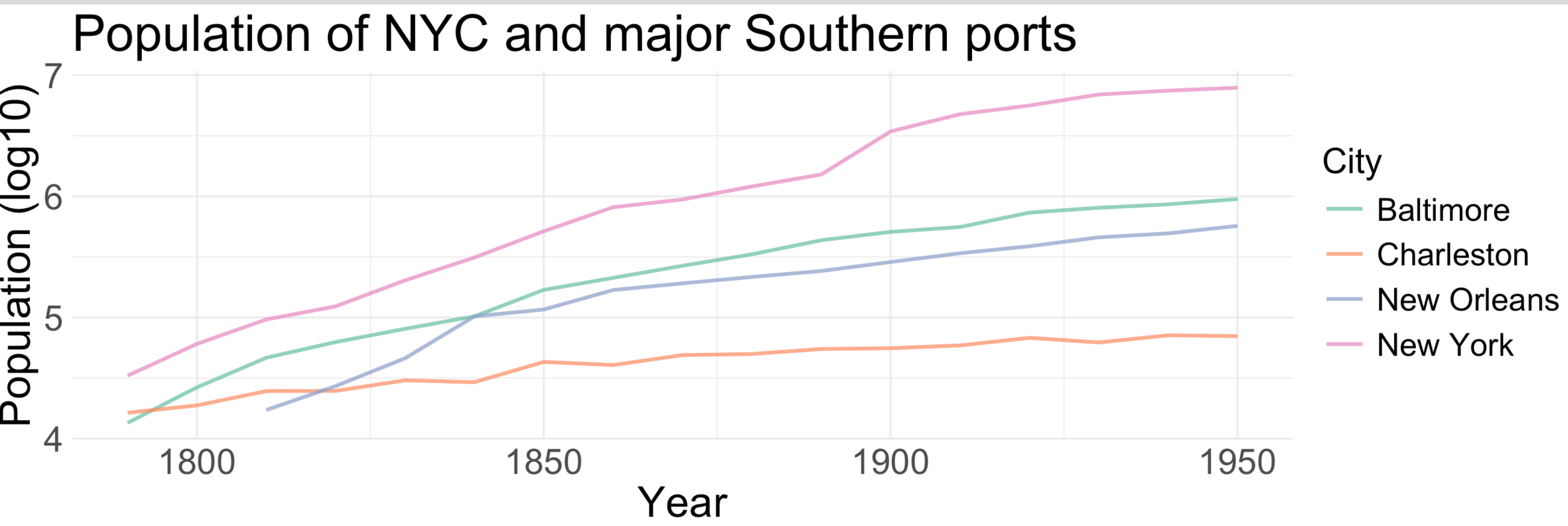


Figure 1. Population of New York, Baltimore New Orleans, and Charleston from 1790 to 1950.

4. METHODS AND DATA

- Baltimore Neighborhood Heritage Project (BNHP; Shopes 1981; Renwick et al. 2026)
 - 232 oral histories of Baltimore residents collected in 1978–1981
 - Speakers born 1879–1951
 - Data currently available from 7 Black speakers and 7 white speakers from Baltimore City or Baltimore County
- Fieldwork in Baltimore
 - 45 interviews (so far) with natives of Baltimore and its inner suburbs
 - Speakers born 1940–2002
 - Data currently available from 13 Black speakers, 20 white speakers, and 1 Asian American speaker
- Data processing:
 - Diarization for BNHP (Bleaman & Sprouse 2023)
 - Forced alignment with MFA’s English (US) ARPA model (McAuliffe et al. 2017; McAuliffe & Sonderegger 2024)
 - Formant extraction
 - with DARLA for BNHP (Reddy & Stanford 2015)
 - with new-fave for our fieldwork (Fruehwald 2025)
 - Outlier removal (Leys et al. 2018)
 - Normalization with ΔF method (Johnson 2020) in `joeyr` (Stanley 2021)

5. PALM IN BALTIMORE

- The Upper South also has PALM backer than LOT (Kurath & McDavid 1961)
- Kurath & McDavid (1961) report:
 - front central LOT versus central PALM in NYC;
 - central LOT versus back (sometimes rounded) PALM in Baltimore (Figure 2).
- The Baltimore system is more likely to develop into PALM-THOUGHT merger.
- Baltimore is also characterized by variable LOT-PALM merger before voiced consonants (Figure 2).
- Some BNHP speakers appear to demonstrate PALM-THOUGHT merger (Figure 3).
- Kurath & McDavid (1961) also report PALM-THOUGHT merger in Tidewater Virginia and the Delmarva Peninsula.
- PALM-THOUGHT merger is common among Black Baltimoreans today (Figure 4), and like in New Orleans:
 - there is lexical variation; and
 - pre-voiced LOT variably merges with THOUGHT as well.

Low back systems of BNHP speakers

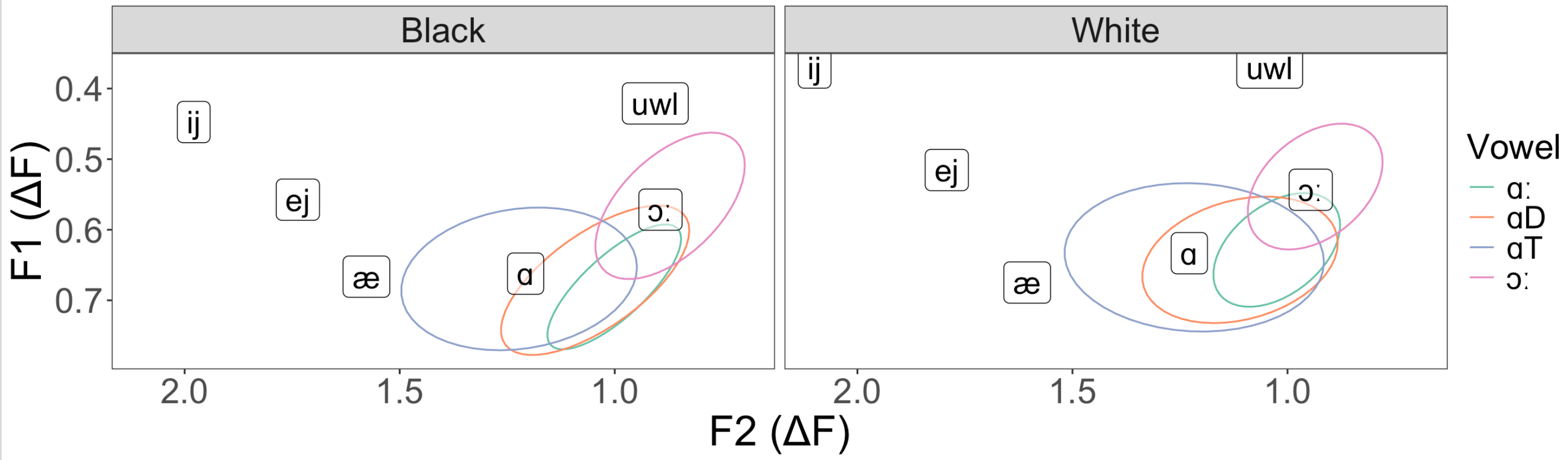


Figure 2. Low back vowels in the BNHP data. /a:/ is PALM, /aD/ is pre-voiced LOT, /aT/ is pre-voiceless LOT, and /o:/ is THOUGHT.

Elmira Deitrich (white, born 1896)

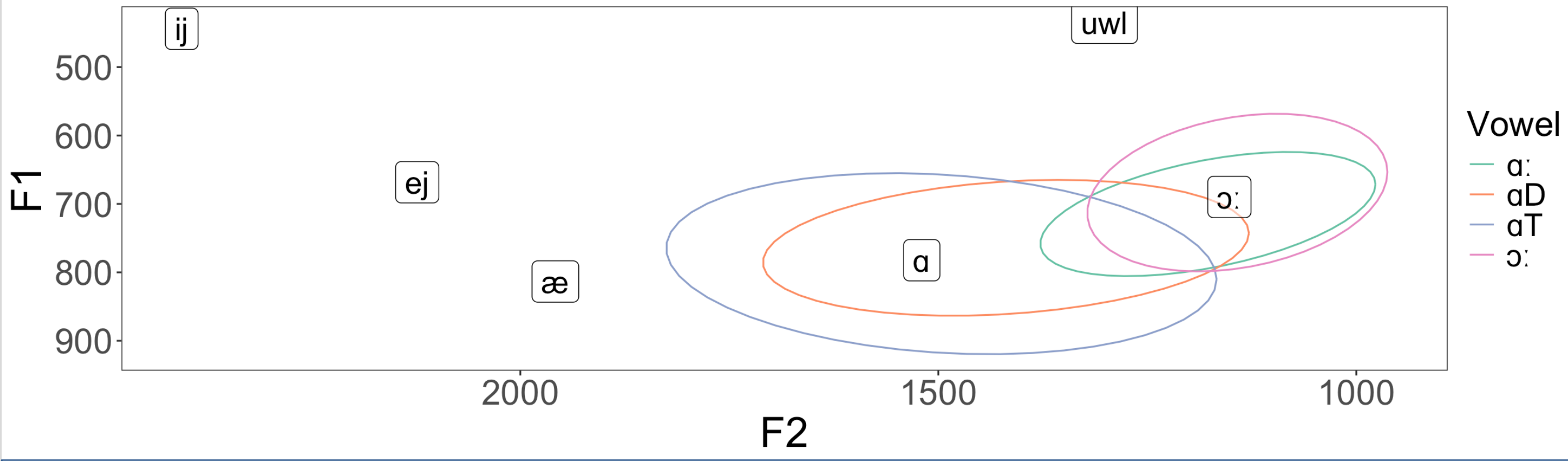


Figure 3. The low back system of Elmira Deitrich.

Arnie (Black, b. 1976)

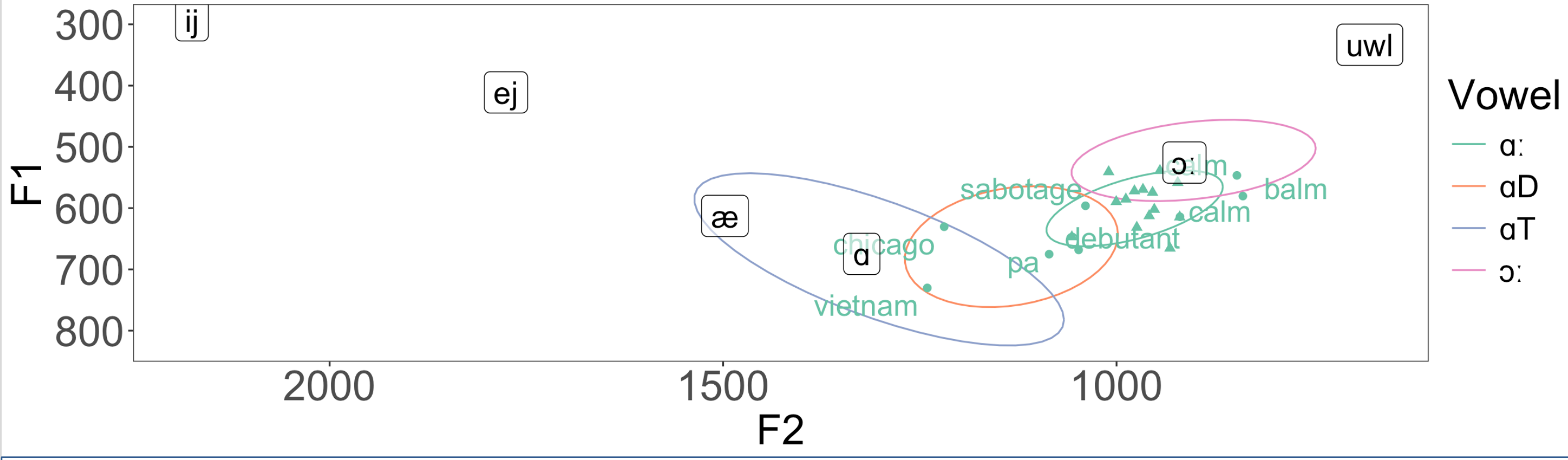


Figure 4. The low back system of Arnie. Unlabeled triangles are tokens of *father* or *grandfather*.

6. DISCUSSION

- The dialects of Baltimore and New Orleans are both characterized by PALM-THOUGHT merger, an uncommon merger not attested in NYC.
- New Orleans and Baltimore share other linguistic features, not all of which are characteristic of NYC or Charleston.
- There is a historical basis for dialect contact between Baltimore and New Orleans.
- Therefore, Baltimore is a plausible source for the New Orleans low back system.
- Further research should continue to investigate the Baltimore’s role in maritime contact on the Atlantic and Gulf coasts, both as a source and a recipient of features.

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REFERENCES. For references, please scan the QR code or enter this link: <https://bit.ly/44EodmQ>.



2. DIFFUSION OF THE NYC LOW BACK SYSTEM?

- NYC historically has a low back system in which:
 - PALM is backer than LOT (Kurath & McDavid 1961; Newman 2016); and
 - pre-voiced LOT merges with PALM (Kaye 2012; Newman 2016).
- Dinkin & Carmichael (2024) report that among white New Orleanians:
 - PALM is merged with THOUGHT; and
 - pre-voiced LOT variably merges with THOUGHT.
- They argue that:
 - New Orleans formerly had the same low back configuration as NYC
 - as a result of diffusion from NYC.

3. BALTIMORE-NEW ORLEANS CONNECTIONS

- Baltimore was the largest Southern port from 1800 until 1960 (Figure 1).
- There was an extensive maritime slave trade from Baltimore to New Orleans (Williams 2020).
- Many slaveowners migrated from Maryland to New Orleans (Williams 2020).